

Rhythm percussion

Supporting the overall musical texture, rhythm percussion drives forward the music and provides a consistent beat throughout a piece. Most rhythm percussion instruments are untuned. Their key role is to emphasize particular rhythms, especially those associated with certain styles, or genres, of music—for example, Latin dance rhythms such as tango.



A drum brush consists of a fan of bristles inserted into a handle.

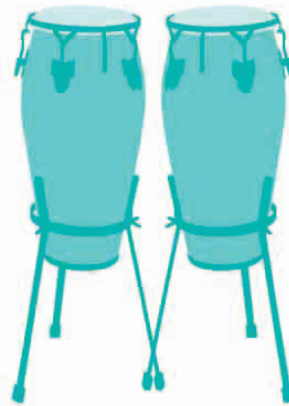


△ Brushes

A drum “brush” can be drawn across the drum head to create a soft rustling effect rather than the hard strike of a wooden stick.

△ Castanets

Castanets are a pair of shell-shaped wooden clappers joined with a string on one edge, and clashed between the thumb and forefinger.



△ Conga drums

These tall, single-headed, South American drums are played with the palms and fingers, and usually feature in groups of two or four.



△ Hi-hat cymbals

An essential part of a drum kit, the hi-hat consists of a pair of cymbals that can be clashed together and opened by a foot-operated pedal.

LOOKING CLOSER

Writing for percussion

Percussion parts are arranged in different ways depending on the style of the music. Tuned instruments need to use treble and bass staves, while untuned, rhythm-only instruments, like most drums, use symbols on a staff with no clef. Occasionally, percussionists will find they need to play several instruments, all notated on the same part of the staff.

▽ Orchestral notation

In orchestral music, each instrument is notated separately in its own part, so that players can move around the platform from one instrument to the next as required. Shown below is the snare drum part of Ravel's *Boléro*.

Snare drum solo in Ravel's famous *Boléro*

Distinctive triplet rhythm

	Hi-hat open	○
	Tom-tom 1	●
	Snare drum	●
	Tom-tom 2	●
	Kick drum	●
	Hi-hat (pedal)	×

◁ Drum kit notation

Drum kit players usually have all their instruments notated in one part, using different symbols to identify which instrument is needed at any point.